Delivery Pipeline Canvas

Map how a change gets from a developer's commit to customers, find where it waits or fails, and pick the next fix.

Engineering Practices · Continuous Integration & Delivery · Inspired by Continuous Delivery (Humble & Farley)

WORKED EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL TEAM

TEAM / SYSTEM: Basket web app

DATE: 15 May

1 Pipeline Stages

FROM COMMIT TO CUSTOMER · ADD OR RENAME STAGES TO MATCH YOURS

Commit & review
Merge to main, peer review

- Time: 1 h
- Waits before: 4 h
- Fails: rarely
- Manual steps: review
- Gate: 1 approval
- Tool: Git
- Owner: devs

Build
Compile, package, version

- Time: 6 min
- Waits before: –
- Fails: 2%
- Manual steps: none
- Gate: it builds
- Tool: CI server
- Owner: Platform

Automated tests
Unit, integration, end-to-end

- Time: 14 min
- Waits before: –
- Fails: 8% (flaky)
- Manual steps: none
- Gate: all pass
- Tool: CI server
- Owner: Alex

Quality & security
Scans, checks, approvals

- Time: 5 min
- Waits before: –
- Fails: 1%
- Manual steps: none
- Gate: no high risks
- Tool: scanner
- Owner: Platform

Deploy to test
Staging or pre-production

- Time: 8 min
- Waits before: –
- Fails: staging down
- Manual steps: none
- Gate: smoke tests
- Tool: deploy tool
- Owner: Platform

Release
Production, to users

- Time: 3 min
- Waits before: 1 day
- Fails: rarely
- Manual steps: a button
- Gate: self-service checks
- Tool: deploy tool
- Owner: team

Monitor
Is it working for users?

- Time: –
- Waits before: –
- Fails: –
- Manual steps: none
- Gate: alerts on errors
- Tool: dashboards
- Owner: on-call

2 Totals & Signals

THE WHOLE PIPELINE

- Commit to production, typical: about 2 days
- Time to fix a broken build: about 1 hour
- Of that, time spent waiting: over 90%
- Flaky or skipped steps: 6 flaky tests
- Pipeline runs per day: 25
- Deploys per week: 3
- Runs that fail: 10%
- Releases rolled back: 1 in April

Fast feedback matters most: aim for a build and test run that finishes in minutes, not hours.

3 Bottlenecks & Pain

WHERE DOES WORK WAIT, FAIL OR NEED A PERSON?

- Reviews wait half a day
- Releases wait a day for a slot
- Flaky reorder tests: reruns
- Staging goes down
- No alert on payment-provider errors
- Rollback is a manual script

4 Next Improvement

ONE CHANGE AT A TIME

- The change we'll make: fix or quarantine the 6 flaky tests
- Expected effect (which number moves?): runs that fail: 10% → 3%
- Owner: Ravi, with Alex
- Check it on: end of Sprint 19

5 Signs of a Healthy Pipeline

TICK WHAT'S TRUE TODAY

- [x] Every change goes through the same pipeline
- [ ] A broken build is fixed first
- [x] Deploying is one click, or none
- [x] Main is always releasable
- [x] Tests and config live in version control
- [ ] We can roll back in minutes

"Where does a change spend most of its time waiting?"

"What would it take to release any day we choose?"

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